

1820–1830

DELIGHTING IN THE DETAIL

The widening and shortening of skirt hems in the 1820s revealed footwear and, on occasion, stockings and ankles. A wide waistband helped to lower the waist, enabling alterations through the addition of a strip of extra fabric under the belt. Piping appeared on bodices and cuffs and persisted until around 1870. Dress bodices were uniformly back fastened, while spencer jackets and pelisses opened at centre front. The pelisse evolved into a redingote (literally riding coat). Fashion plate distinctions between outfits for different occasions were not so clear in real life – people adapted what they had. On the death of George IV (June 1830), various stages of mourning were shown, as a lavender-grey filter descended on fashion.

HATS AND BONNETS



Hat with
feathers



Hat with
artificial
flowers

The 1820s were typified by elaborate hats and bonnets that revealed faces, and were poised at jaunty side angles. Front temple curls or smooth-parted hair was always visible under muslin or lawn caps. Headwear was of straw, velvet, or silk on a firm foundation, or fabric drawn across cane or wire. Feathers and artificial flowers on top were balanced by ribbons fashioned into bows and roses under the brim. There were endless variations on a theme, ever more stylish and extravagant. Ribbons of silk gauze were highly prized. Trimmings were often pinned in place, and moved from one hat or bonnet to another.



Mourning
handkerchief

Low-key
decoration of
double zigzag
and leaves

White crêpe
hat with
ribbons and
feathers

Fine cotton
chemisette with
vertical tucking
and bow

1830

French grey Mourning dress for the king in July 1830 saw black and white stripes. In August mourning continued, as here, with French grey afternoon dresses and white cotton trimmings. Sleeves are in “double bouffant” puffed shapes to the wrist.

Matching purple
bonnet lined with
cerise silk

Cap of
embroidered
muslin

Line of decorative,
self-covered
buttons to sleeve

1824



Travelwear This winter coat is fastened with buttons. It has a fur hem (and possibly lining), complemented by a shaggy fur muff. Muffs of bearskin and goatskin were popular, and a useful accessory for travelling.



Black hat
with violet
ribbons

Elizabethan-
style ruff

Fichu-pelerine

Matching
wrist
bracelets

Overskirt

Short skirt
reveals two-tone
walking boots

Cording detail This mourning dress is of plain violet fabric, with cording to fichu-pelerine and overskirt. The shoulder line shows carriage pleating into the gigot sleeves, as the shape evolves and fullness moves down the upper arm.